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101 Cargos / 101 Travellers

Review by Robert Prior

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***101 Cargos* by Andy and Sarah Lilly**

***101 Travellers* by Andy and Sarah Lilly**

British Isles Traveller Support is best known as the publishers of the 101 series (*Traveller's* "Little White Books"). The 101 series is aimed at helping *Traveller* referees stumped for information. Rather than a grand campaign, they provide small vignettes designed to be dropped into any game. While all were written for Milieu Zero, they can be transplanted to the 1100s with little difficulty.

All 101 books have the same format — an 8.5" x 6" black-and-white booklet, with a color cover protected by a stiff plastic sheet. The print is small but readable, and the layout is clear. There are no diagrams.

Your *Traveller* group was raised on stories of Nicholas van Rijn and the Polesotechnic League, so you purchased *GT: Far Trader*, created characters, calculated trade routes for the entire sector, and started a one-ship merchant company with big ambitions — yet something is missing from your trading games. You've tried to make each trip unique, but your imagination is faltering and somehow accounting is overshadowing roleplaying.

101 Cargos and *101 Travellers* may be just what you need.

101 Cargos

You're kidding, right? We don't ship livestock! No, I don't care what your manifest says, the contract I've signed here says dead, D-E-A-D — dead! Feeding? Look, I said I'm not taking them — this says ... it doesn't? No, look, "queriaghg" is "dead," right? No? Well, what the ... the extra "g" makes it future tense, does it ... so they're going to be dead but are currently alive ... and require feeding ... and mucking out ... and we'll have to leave the hold pressurized ... where's Pendle? Trust him to misinterpret this! Why don't these people use Galanglic on their forms? Come on, where's Pendle? I'm going to wring his #\$\$&\$* neck!

— Captain James Hacker, Merchant Ship *Endeavour*

101 Cargos is much more than just a listing of cargos — each chapter contains ideas linking adventures with cargos. (At first, this was just another shipment of machine parts, but a competitor has approached one of the players to steal a sample, a customs agent is panicking because the radio-isotopes in the power supplies are mislabeled, and ...)

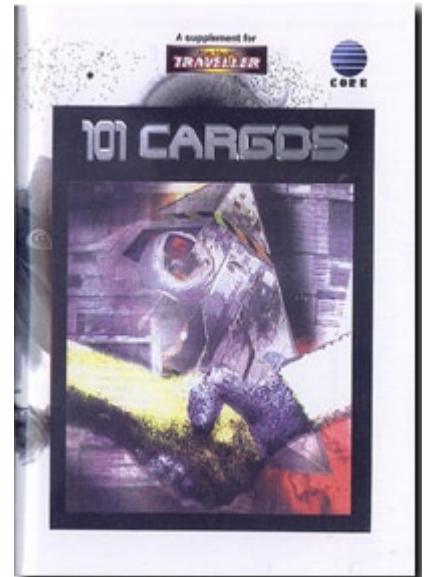
The first chapter, *Instant Adventure Links*, provides some tables for randomly generating plot hooks linked to specific cargo items. While still requiring referee work, these serve as a nice prod to the imagination for an overworked referee who's fallen into a rut.

The second chapter, *Shipping Codes*, details a set of shipping labels for fragile, perishable, and hazardous goods. While at first glance this looks like a color item, consider the adventure possibilities inherent in a transposed hazard code, or the consequences when an overzealous customs cadet labels the players' cargo of flour "explosive!" (A potentially true label — flour/air mixtures are explosive — but extremely misleading nonetheless ...)

The next five chapters provide sample cargos, divided into Natural Resources, Processed Resources, Manufactured Goods, Information, and Novelties. From hellboria planks to zipwire racquets, a bare trade classification — such as plants (wood) or fad manufactured good — are expanded in several paragraphs of color text, with handling requirements and possible adventure hooks.

A glossary collects all new terms and named items together, describing them as library data entries.

Finally, the last chapter contains yet another system for generating detailed cargo. Unlike *Far Trader*, where the prices are of paramount concern and the cargo's nature is determined afterward, *101 Cargos* generates the trade good first, which then determines both base price and special characteristics. This chapter will require a bit more work to modify for *GURPS Traveller* than the rest of the book, but is still useful.



101 Travellers

"Good afternoon, Miss Smith. Glad to have you traveling with us. Could I just check your booking details ..."

"Thank you. And this is your luggage?"

"You packed this yourself?"

"No, I just wondered. Do you mind if I check the contents?"

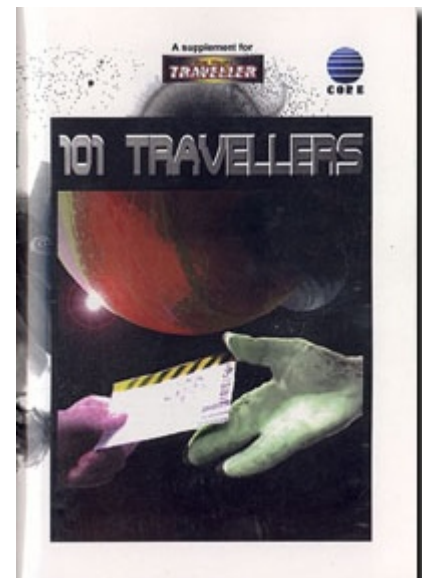
"No, of course I'm not picking on you, Miss Smith. No, it's nothing to do with your eye patch ..."

"No, really, we've already processed the quarantine details for your parrot, and as long as he stays perched on your shoulder and doesn't annoy the other passengers ..."

"Now that's hardly fair, Miss Smith! Of course I realize you're disabled — the ticket clearly states that one of your lower legs is a robotic prosthesis ..."

"Well, frankly, Miss Smith, it's the muzzle of the gauss rifle that's protruding from your prosthetic leg, the faint ticking sound coming from your parrot, and the way our trained dog passed out as it began sniffing your luggage ..."

— Septimus Lither, captain of *The Leaping Lizard*



While the ship's steward may prefer that passengers stay nicely bland and anonymous, anyone who has worked in the hospitality field will tell you this is an unreasonable expectation. Besides, it's boring. Realism and game drama both dictate that passengers should be individuals, each with his own skills, personality, and motivations.

Of course, asking your referee to come up with a dozen detailed NPCs every couple of weeks is a bit much. Give them this book instead.

101 Travellers provides, well, 101 travelers, neatly sorted according to ticket class and group size. Every entry follows the same format:

Personal details: race, sex, age, UPP, skills, spending money, etc.

A visual description.

Background information, including their reason for traveling.

Play options, suggesting ways that they can make the characters' lives interesting.

A small glossary provides library data entries for the new organizations and items mentioned in the book. There is some tie-in with ***101 Cargos***, which is a nice touch.

The biggest downside to *101 Travellers* is that character statistics are given in ***T4*** format only; ***GURPS Traveller*** referees will have to convert the NPC characteristics and skills (using the guidelines on p. GT124). But this is a minor inconvenience — the book would be useful even if no game statistics were given at all.

Summary

Both books provide good value for money.

Editor's Note: Both books are available through Warehouse 23.